



Productside

AI-AUGMENTED PRODUCT DISCOVERY

Build the Right Thing Before Building It Right.

AI made building dramatically cheaper and faster.
It did not make knowing what to build any easier.

Follow along



<https://bit.ly/build-the-right-thing-Oct26>

Just because you can

...

Doesn't mean you
should!

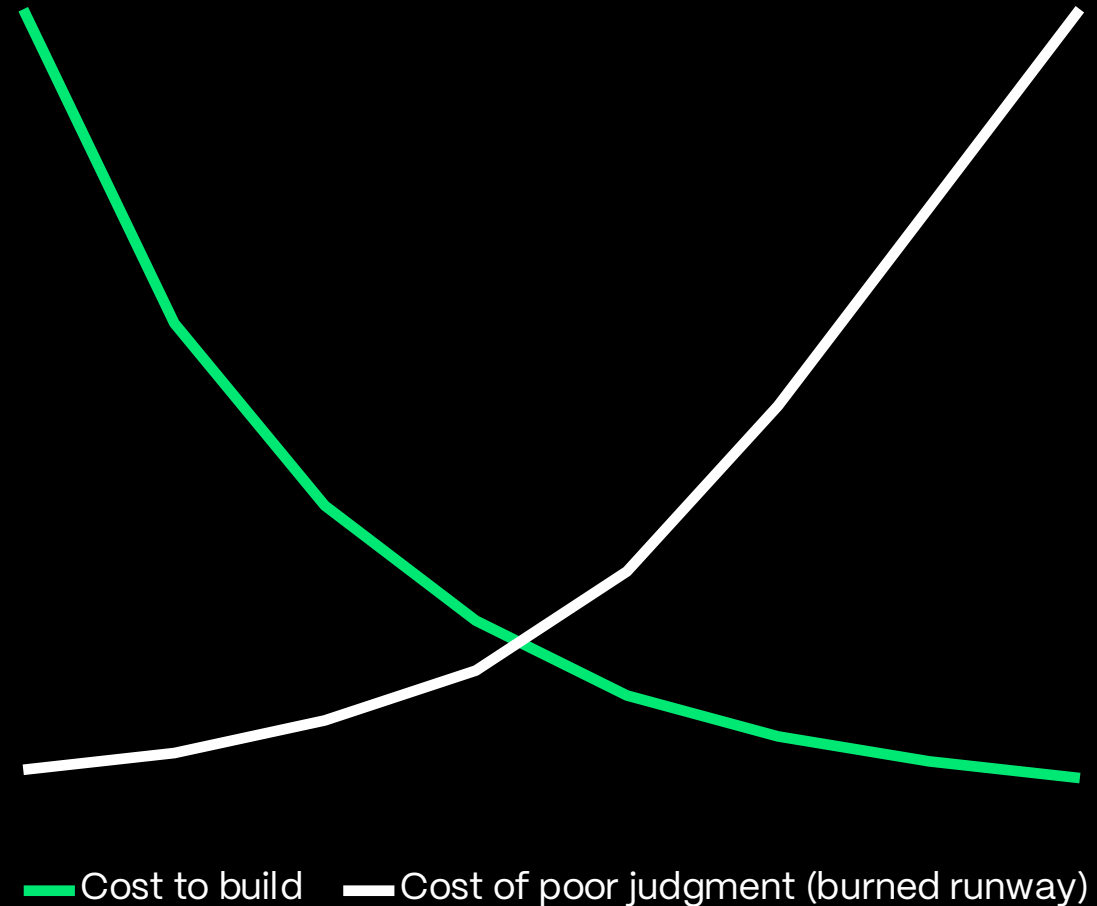
Examples of Building the Wrong thing the Right Way

- | | | |
|-----------|------------------------|--|
| 01 | Relay.app | Lost \$8.1M discovering differentiation must keep being earned. |
| 02 | Humane AI Pin | Blew ~\$120m learning Novelty does not equal customer value . |
| 03 | Gemini Human image gen | Lost brand equity optimizing one thing can break another. |
| 04 | Air Canada chatbot | Learned the hard way automation does not outsource accountability . |
| 05 | Zillow Offers | \$500m learning model performance does not equal viability . |

Welcome to the AI cost paradox

Teams can now **build the wrong** thing faster, and polish a weak assumption into a shipped feature.

Progress means uncertainty reduced, jobs identified, and gains realized ... **not activity increased.**



Illustrative shape only. Not measured data.

CONSIDER THE COSTS

IRL Examples of the AI Cost Paradox

- | | | |
|----|-----------|--|
| 01 | Uber | Burned through a year's AI coding budget in four months |
| 02 | Priceline | Their Cursor renewal reportedly increased ~350% |
| 03 | JellyFish | Reported users realizing only 2× productivity using 10× the tokens |
| 04 | Axios | Employees found burning tokens using AI models to check the weather |
| 05 | WSJ | Only 11% of 398 orgs surveyed forecast AI spending within $\pm 10\%$ accuracy |

Grew up here...

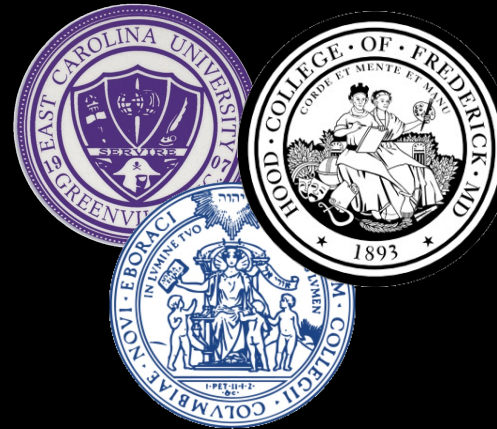


Learned Product Management here...



DEAN PETERS

Went to school here...



Happy to be here...



Product Management
Consultant & Trainer

35 Years of
professional
experience

Years in
product
management 20

Led multiple products lines
to consecutive years of

double-digit
revenue growth

Experience managing
complex portfolios of
Hardware, software,
and service Products,
including leading various
AI, API, and IIoT initiatives

WHERE I WORK

Productside

Your Outcome-driven Product Partner

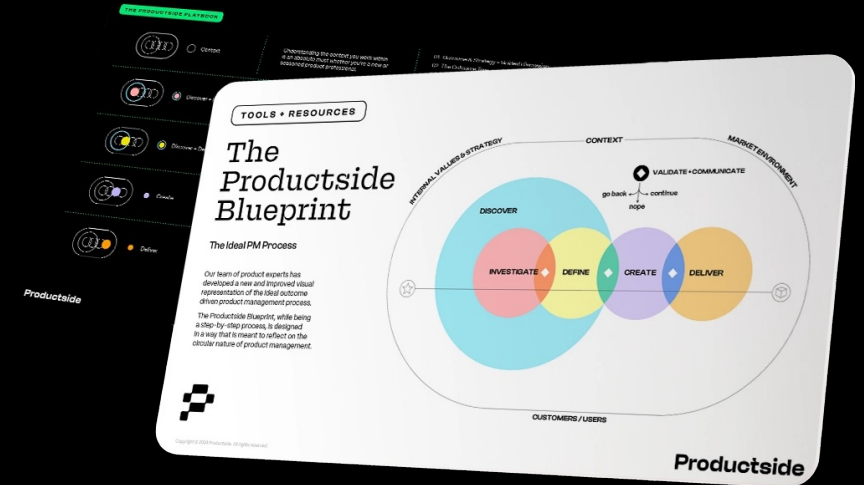
WHY CLIENTS CHOOSE US

COMPLETE
SOLUTION FOR
TRANSFORMATION

TAILORED TO YOUR
CONTEXT

INVESTED EXPERTS

We help product
teams **build**
products people
want to **buy and use**



What problem are we
solving, and for
whom?

**Build an AI-enhanced
maintenance dashboard for
managers at mid-sized
manufacturers.**

UNKNOWN

What would you need to know before funding that?

NOTE: This manufacturing scenario is SYNTHETIC. No customers were interviewed. These aren't customers. They're hypothesis-generating machines.

01

Market Intel

What is the landscape, and how much of what we know is evidence?

ARTIFACT: MARKET INTELLIGENCE BRIEF

RULE A market sweep is not a segment.

HANDOFF CARD

TARGET

BELIEF

EVIDENCE

INFERRED

OUTCOME

QUESTION

THE EVIDENCE LEGEND

ACTUAL DATA

INFERRED

ESTIMATE

UNKNOWN

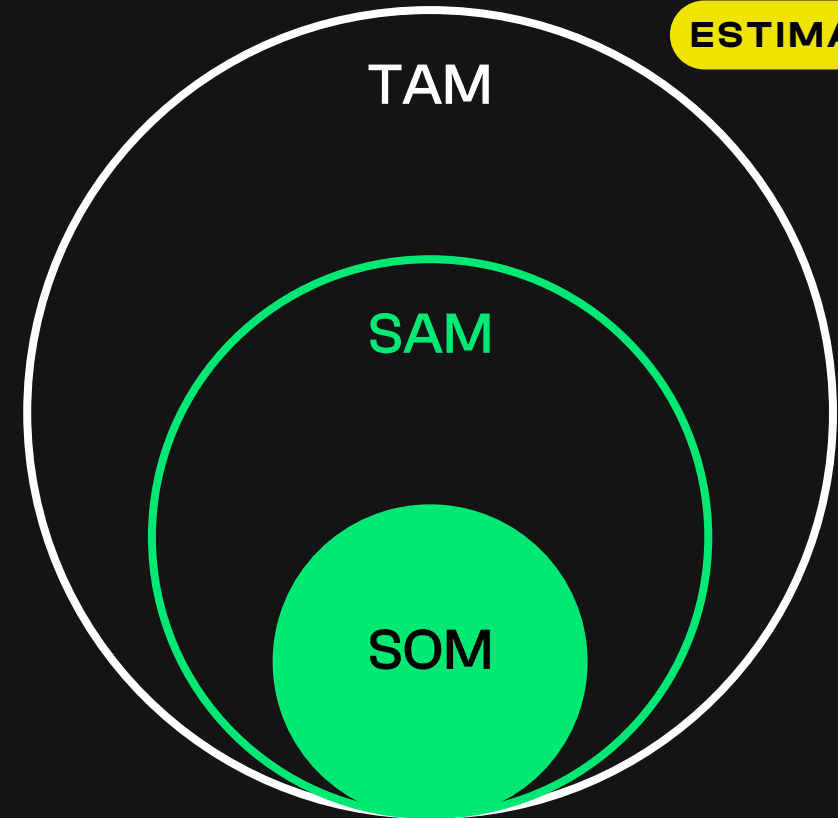
02

Segment

Which bounded context are we deliberately choosing to learn about?

ARTIFACT: SEGMENT SELECTION BRIEF

RULE Sizing is an estimate until it is sourced.
Choosing a segment is not proof it is attractive.



TAM from population

SAM from trade and industry

SOM from competition and reach

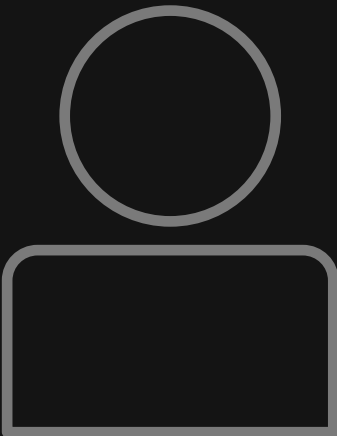
03a Proto-Persona

Who is this persona, in what situation, trying to make what progress?

NAME

Maintenance manager

PORTRAIT



an archetype, not a person

BIO

Mid-sized plant

Flood of early warning signals

Checks logs, asks a tech

OUTCOMES

Catch emerging failures early

Prioritize right intervention

QUOTES

"Which signals actually matter?"

"What fails if I do nothing?"

"Is the fix worth the downtime?"

PAINS

Balance interventions vs. uptime

Ad hoc issues on the rise

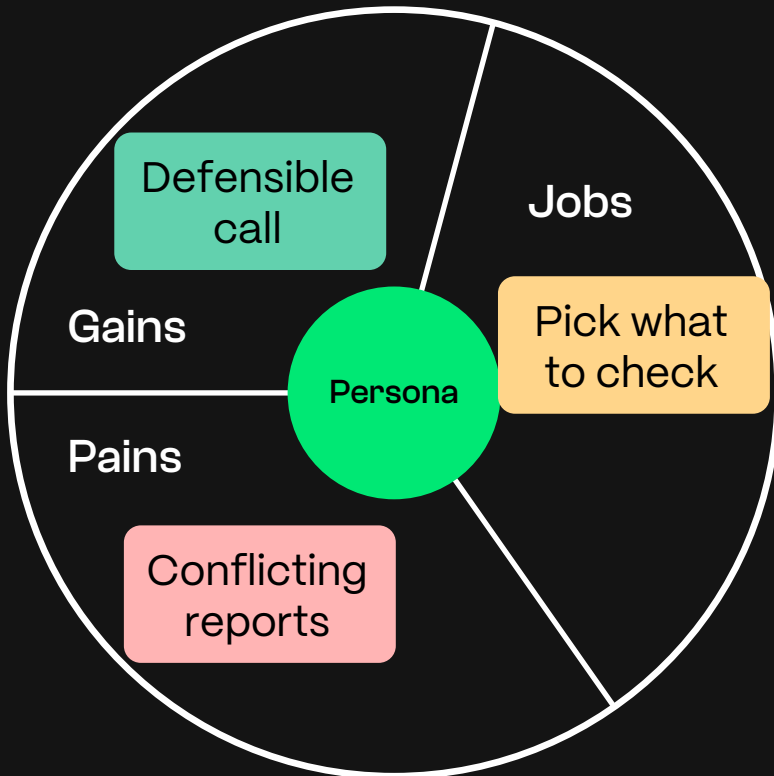
ARTIFACT: SITUATIONAL PERSONA

RULE A hypothesis, not a customer we interviewed.

03b Problem Framing

What is job is the persona trying to achieve, what is their goal, what pains get in the way?

1 List



2 Pick the top

Top job

Pick what to check next

Top gain

Explain it fast

Top pain

Reports disagree

3 Frame the problem

I am a maintenance manager.

Trying to pick what to check next.

But the reports disagree.

Because source and timing are hidden.

Makes me feel unsure.

SYNTHETIC. ALL ESTIMATE.

ARTIFACT: SITUATIONAL PERSONA

RULE A hypothesis, not a customer we interviewed.

Where do we play,
Where do we win?

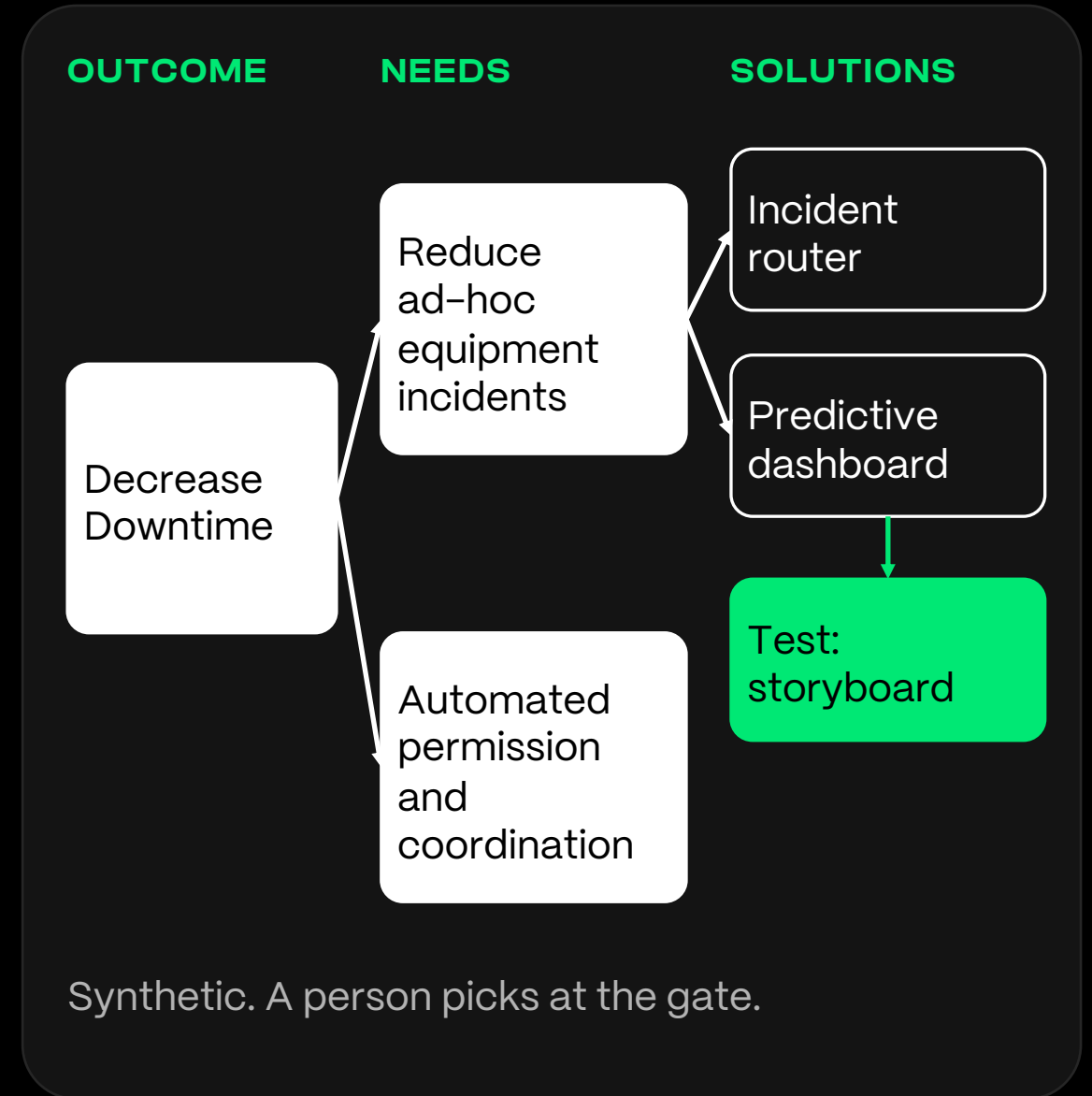
04

Opportunity Solution Tree

Which needs are worth pursuing, and which solutions and cheap experiments hang off them?

ARTIFACT: OPPORTUNITY SOLUTION TREE

RULE Incoming ideas 'a dashboard' is a solution candidate, not an outcome, not a need, and not an opportunity.



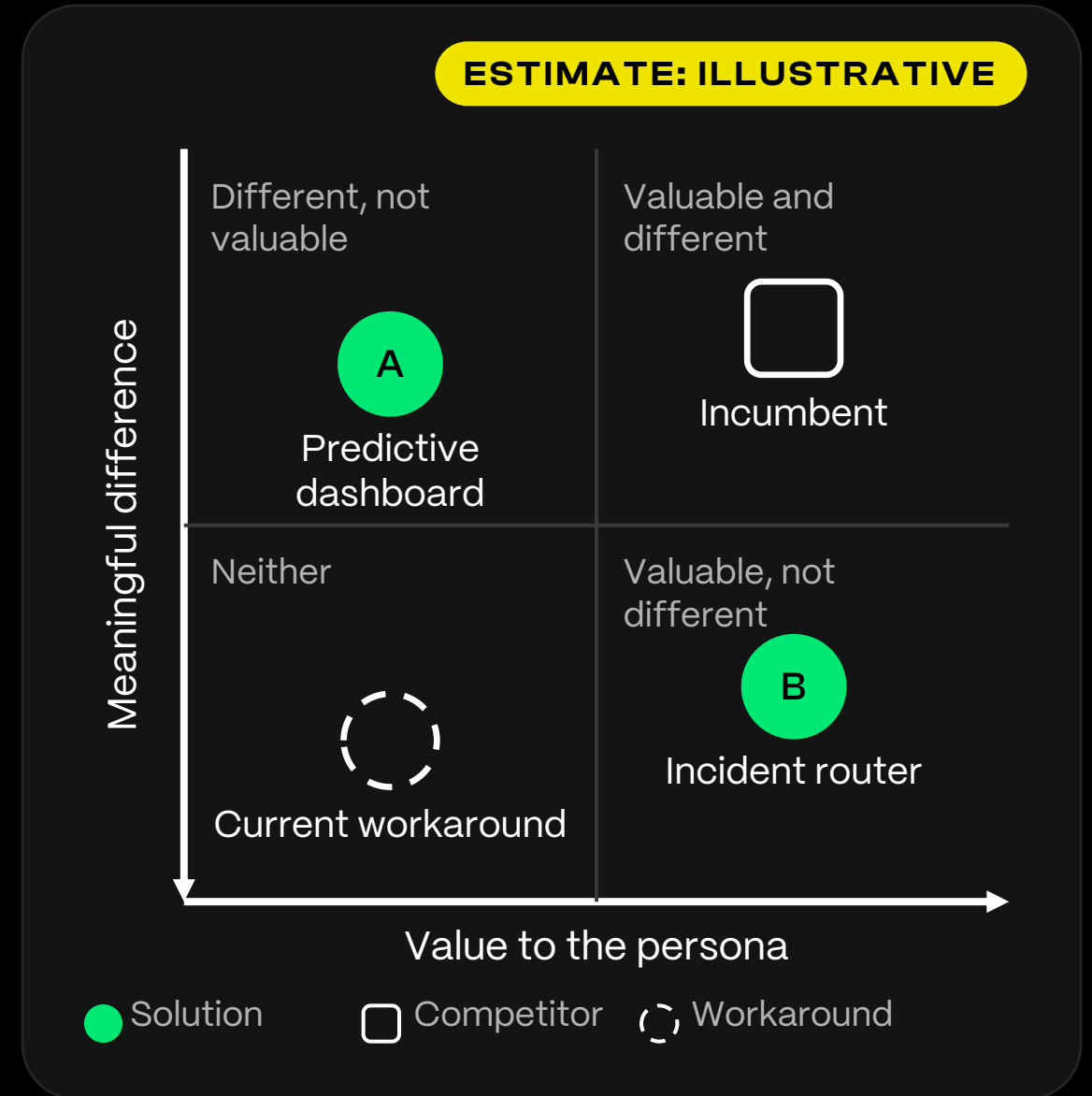
05

Value Prop vs. Differentiation 2x2

Where does each solution from the tree sit? Does the value matter, and is the difference meaningful?

ARTIFACT: 2X2

RULE Different is not the same as valuable.
AI novelty is evidence of neither.



06 Positioning Statement

Why is this for this persona, and why would they choose it over today's workaround?

For	maintenance managers
Who	want to get out in front of common issues
The	predictive trends dashboard
Is a	decision aid
That	offers proactive interventions
Unlike	reacting to exceptions
Our product gives	recommendations based on history & telemetry

ARTIFACT: POSITIONING STATEMENT

RULE A proposed difference is not a reason to believe.

What must be true,
how do we learn?

07 Solution Hypothesis

What do we believe will change, and what would make us revise or stop?

IF / THEN

NOT RUN

If we flag emerging equipment risks and explain why they matter,
for maintenance managers,
then we will help them decide what to inspect or intervene on before failure.

2 TINY ACTS OF DISCOVERY

1. Review recent failures to identify causes
2. Simulate equipment failures using synthetic IIoT data

QUANTITATIVE + QUALITATIVE METRIC

1. Reduce % of failures via interventions
2. Increase manager confidence in identifying emerging issues

REVISE OR STOP IF

Revise or stop if predictions fail to change maintenance outcomes.

ARTIFACT: SOLUTION HYPOTHESIS

RULE Write the rule before the result exists.

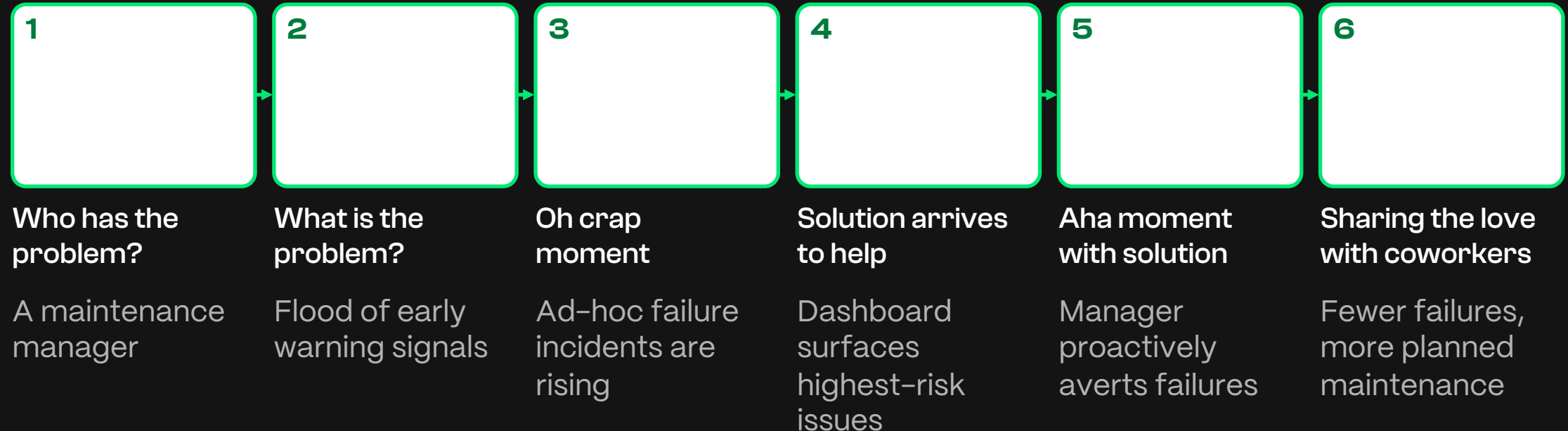
08 Storyboard

What does the story look like, from who has the problem to who else gets the win?

SOLUTION SUMMARY

NOT RENDERED | SYNTHETIC

If we surface the highest-risk equipment early, managers can intervene before failure.



ARTIFACT: STORYBOARD

RULE Aim for authenticity, simplicity and emotion.

09

Minimum Viable Narrative

What is the smallest story worth testing?

PROTOTYPE HYPOTHESIS

Surface the highest-risk equipment so managers can intervene before failure.

TARGET AUDIENCE

A maintenance manager at a mid-sized manufacturing plant

SETUP

Overwhelming flood of warning signals

ENCOUNTER

Dashboard highlights highest-risk incidents

LOOP: 3 TO 6 EXCHANGES

ACTION

Manager picks & investigates incident details

RESPONSE

Risks, evidences, causes, & then recommendation

RESOLUTION

Manager proactively averts a failure

BUILDER PROMPT

Be descriptive, not prescriptive.

NOT BUILT

ARTIFACT: MINIMUM VIABLE NARRATIVE

RULE The smallest story worth testing.

10

Prototyping

What's the **tiniest act of discovery** that returns **the most brutal truth** that **helps us decide** whether we **pivot, punt, or pursue** the prototyped concept

ARTIFACT: PROTOTYPE EXPERIMENT BRIEF

RULE Don't say NO to the HiPPO.
Run the the discovery chain instead.

~~Build an AI-enhanced
maintenance
dashboard for
managers at mid-sized
manufacturers.~~

TEST THE PREDICTION,
NOT THE DASHBOARD

The fidelity ladder

Lo-fi, if it tells the truth.

What can we learn at this fidelity that we could not learn more cheaply?

“The most expensive way to test your idea is to build **production quality software.**”

Jeff Patton



Starting Today, What Will You Do Differently?

PROMPT

Explore

Create a library to
paste it into any chat.

SKILL

Codify

Define and share
bounded, repeatable
plays.

AGENT

Delegate

Use AI as an operator
to pursue outcomes
over outputs.

PLUGIN

Distribute

Create installable
own tools for yourself
and your team?

Ten artifacts do not prove demand.
Automating their generation does not prove value.
But building your own tools and working smarter help.

Learn faster.
Decide better.
Then build.



Download our state of AI for
Product Management report

Visit the repo we referenced today:

<https://bit.ly/deans-discovery-lab>



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